

Freedom of Information (FOI) Annual Report (2024)

Company A - National Data Management Office
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Executive Summary

1.1 Purpose of This Report

This Annual Report provides a comprehensive overview of Company A's Freedom of Information (FOI) program performance during the 2024 calendar year. The report demonstrates Company A's commitment to transparency, accountability, and compliance with Saudi Arabia's Right to Information framework and the National Data Management Office (NDMO) regulations.

The report fulfills our statutory obligation to publish annual statistics on FOI request handling while also serving as a tool for continuous improvement and public accountability. It is published on our Open Data Portal (opendata.companya.gov.sa) and distributed to key stakeholders including the National Data Management Office, the Ministry of Health, and civil society organizations.

1.2 Legislative Framework

Company A's FOI program operates under the following legal and regulatory framework:

Primary Legislation:

- Personal Data Protection Law (PDPL) - Royal Decree M/19, 2021
- NDMO National Data Management Regulations - 191 Controls across 15 Domains
- Saudi Open Data Policy - Council of Ministers Decision 2024
- Healthcare Information Privacy Standards - Saudi Health Council Guidelines

Internal Policies:

- FOI Policy v2.0 (Approved: March 2024)
- Data Classification Policy v3.1 (Approved: January 2024)
- Information Security Policy v4.0 (Approved: February 2024)
- Records Management Policy v2.5 (Approved: April 2024)

1.3 Key Performance Highlights

Company A's FOI program achieved excellent results in 2024, demonstrating our commitment to openness and transparency:

Volume & Outcomes:

- Total Requests Received: 45 requests (compared to 38 in 2023, representing an 18% increase)
- Fully Granted: 38 requests (84% of total)
- Partially Granted: 5 requests (11% of total)
- Denied: 2 requests (5% of total)
- Overall Disclosure Rate: 95% (fully + partially granted)

Processing Efficiency:

- Average Response Time: 12 days (compared to 16 days in 2023, representing a 25% improvement)
- Regulatory SLA: 30 days maximum
- SLA Compliance Rate: 100% (all 45 requests responded to within the statutory timeframe)
- Median Response Time: 10 days
- Fastest Response: 3 days
- Most Complex Request: 28 days

Cost Efficiency:

- Total Program Cost: SAR 185,000 (staff time, technology, training)
- Cost per Request: SAR 4,111
- Fee Revenue Collected: SAR 2,450 (document reproduction fees)
- Net Cost: SAR 182,550

Proactive Disclosure:

- New Datasets Published: 18 datasets added to Open Data Portal
- Open Data Portal Downloads: 148,220 downloads across 100 datasets
- Routine Publication Items: 45 documents proactively published (meeting minutes, policies, budgets)

Quality Metrics:

- Complaints Received: 1 complaint (2.2% of requests)
- Appeals Filed: 0 appeals
- Internal Audit Score: 96% (assessed by Internal Audit Department in November 2024)
- Requester Satisfaction: 4.3/5.0 (based on 28 survey responses)

1.4 Strategic Improvements Planned for 2025

Building on our 2024 success, Company A will implement the following enhancements in 2025:

Technology Improvements:

1. Launch online FOI request portal (currently email-based)
2. Implement automated workflow system for request tracking and assignment
3. Deploy redaction software to improve efficiency and accuracy
4. Integrate FOI system with Document Management System (OpenText)

Process Optimization:

1. Reduce average response time target from 12 days to 9 days
2. Expand routine publication scheme to include additional document categories
3. Implement quarterly FOI training for all department heads
4. Establish FOI Coordinator role in each department

Transparency Initiatives:

1. Publish quarterly FOI statistics (currently annual only)
2. Create interactive FOI dashboard on company website
3. Expand Open Data Portal from 100 to 125 datasets
4. Launch multilingual support (Arabic + English) for FOI requests

Stakeholder Engagement:

1. Host annual FOI Open House for public education
2. Establish FOI Advisory Committee with external members
3. Conduct proactive outreach to researchers and media
4. Publish FOI Annual Report in Q1 (currently published in Q4)

2. Introduction

2.1 About Company A's FOI Program

Company A is a Saudi Arabian government healthcare entity providing comprehensive medical services to over 2 million citizens annually across 47 clinics and 5 major hospitals. As a public sector organization, we are committed to the principles of transparency, accountability, and good governance.

Our FOI program was formally established in 2022 following the enactment of Saudi Arabia's broader transparency initiatives and NDMO regulations. The program provides a structured mechanism for citizens, researchers, media, and other stakeholders to access non-sensitive information held by Company A.

FOI Program Scope:

The FOI program covers all information held by Company A, subject to legal exemptions for:

- Personal data protected by PDPL
- Information classified as SECRET or CONFIDENTIAL under our Data Classification Policy
- Commercially sensitive information
- Information that would compromise patient safety, security, or ongoing investigations

FOI Team Structure:

- FOI Officer: Mariam Al-Shehri (Full-time, dedicated role since January 2023)
- Deputy FOI Officer: Salem Al-Qahtani (Part-time, 20% FTE)
- Legal Support: Khalid Al-Manea, Legal Counsel (consulted on complex requests)
- IT Support: IT Department provides technical assistance for data extraction and redaction

2.2 FOI Program Objectives

Company A's FOI program has five core objectives aligned with our organizational values and regulatory obligations:

1. Promote Transparency & Accountability

Enable public oversight of Company A's operations, decision-making, and use of public resources. Build trust through openness and responsiveness.

2. Facilitate Research & Innovation

Provide researchers, academics, and innovators with access to de-identified health data and operational information to drive healthcare improvements and evidence-based policymaking.

3. Ensure Legal Compliance

Meet all statutory obligations under NDMO regulations, PDPL, and Saudi Open Data Policy. Maintain robust processes to protect sensitive information while maximizing disclosure.

4. Empower Informed Decision-Making

Provide citizens with information needed to make informed decisions about their healthcare, hold public institutions accountable, and participate in democratic processes.

5. Continuous Improvement

Regularly review and enhance FOI processes, technology, and training to improve efficiency, reduce response times, and increase proactive disclosure.

2.3 Governance Structure

The FOI program operates under the following governance structure:

Board of Directors

- Approves FOI Policy and major exemption decisions
- Reviews annual FOI performance at Q4 Board meeting
- Provides strategic oversight and direction

Executive Leadership (CDO - Chief Data Officer)

- Accountable for FOI program performance
- Approves complex or high-risk disclosure decisions
- Chairs quarterly FOI Steering Committee

FOI Steering Committee

- Members: CDO (Chair), CFO, CMO, Legal Counsel, CISO, FOI Officer
- Meets Quarterly
- Reviews FOI statistics, appeals, complaints, and process improvements
- Approves changes to FOI Policy and procedures

FOI Officer (Mariam Al-Shehri)

- Day-to-day management of FOI program
- Receives, triages, and processes all FOI requests
- Coordinates with departments to gather responsive records
- Makes disclosure decisions (with legal consultation for complex cases)
- Manages appeals and complaints
- Prepares quarterly and annual reports

Department FOI Coordinators (Informal Network)

- 12 departments each have an informal FOI Coordinator
- Assist with locating responsive records
- Provide subject matter expertise
- Attend annual FOI training

2.4 Scope of This Report

This Annual Report covers all FOI requests received between January 1, 2024 and December 31, 2024. The report provides:

- Comprehensive statistics on request volumes, outcomes, and processing times
- Trend analysis comparing 2024 to prior years
- Detailed case studies illustrating complex requests
- Analysis of denials and legal exemptions applied
- Complaints and appeals data
- Proactive disclosure initiatives
- Quality assurance and compliance information
- Lessons learned and 2025 improvement plan

The report is intended for multiple audiences:

- Public: Demonstrating transparency and accountability
- Regulators: Evidencing compliance with NDMO and PDPL requirements
- Board of Directors: Oversight of FOI program performance
- Internal Stakeholders: Understanding FOI processes and responsibilities

3. Request Statistics & Trends

3.1 Total Requests Received

Company A received a total of 45 FOI requests during 2024, representing an 18% increase compared to 2023 (38 requests). This growth reflects increasing public awareness of our FOI program and broader transparency culture within Saudi Arabia.

Year-over-Year Comparison:

Year	Total Requests	Year-over-Year Change	Notes
2022	24	N/A (baseline year)	FOI program launched in April 2022
2023	38	+58%	First full year of operations
2024	45	+18%	Steady growth with improved awareness
2025 (projected)	55-60	+22-33% estimated	Based on Q1 trend analysis

Request Volume Drivers:

The 18% increase in 2024 was driven by several factors:

- 1. Increased Public Awareness: Launch of Open Data Portal in February 2024 raised visibility of Company A's transparency initiatives, with link to FOI request form prominently featured.
- 2. Media Coverage: Two major news articles in March and September 2024 highlighted Company A's FOI program as a best practice example in the Saudi healthcare sector.
- 3. Researcher Engagement: Establishment of partnership with King Saud University in May 2024 led to 8 research-related FOI requests from academic institutions.
- 4. Proactive Outreach: FOI Officer presented at 3 public forums and conferences, distributing FOI informational brochures to 500+ attendees.
- 5. Simplified Process: Improved FOI request form (redesigned in January 2024) reduced complexity and encouraged submissions.

3.2 Request Outcomes

Of the 45 requests received in 2024, outcomes were distributed as follows:

Outcome	Count	Percentage	2023 Comparison
Fully Granted	38	84.4%	81.6% in 2023 (+2.8%)
Partially Granted	5	11.1%	13.2% in 2023 (-2.1%)
Denied	2	4.4%	5.3% in 2023 (-0.9%)
Total	45	100%	38 total in 2023

Overall Disclosure Rate: 95.6% (fully + partially granted combined)

Key Observations:

- 1. High Disclosure Rate: Company A's 95.6% disclosure rate significantly exceeds the Saudi public sector average of 78% (NDMO benchmark data, 2024).
- 2. Improved Full Disclosure: The percentage of fully granted requests increased from 81.6% to 84.4%, demonstrating improved processes and staff training on appropriate disclosure.
- 3. Fewer Denials: Only 2 requests were completely denied in 2024, down from 2023, reflecting our commitment to maximum disclosure consistent with legal obligations.
- 4. Partial Grants: 5 requests required partial redactions to protect personal data or classified information, while disclosing the majority of responsive records.

3.3 Monthly Trend Analysis

Request volumes varied throughout the year, with notable seasonal patterns:

Month	Requests Received	Outcome Summary
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January 2024	2	2 Fully Granted
February 2024	3	3 Fully Granted
March 2024	6	5 Fully Granted, 1 Partially Granted
April 2024	4	4 Fully Granted
May 2024	5	4 Fully Granted, 1 Partially Granted
June 2024	3	3 Fully Granted
July 2024	2	2 Fully Granted
August 2024	4	3 Fully Granted, 1 Denied
September 2024	7	5 Fully Granted, 1 Partially Granted, 1 Denied
October 2024	3	2 Fully Granted, 1 Partially Granted
November 2024	4	4 Fully Granted
December 2024	2	2 Fully Granted

Seasonal Patterns:

- Peak Months: March (6 requests) and September (7 requests) showed elevated volumes, coinciding with:
 - March: Media coverage following publication of 2023 Annual Report
 - September: Academic research season (university semester start)
- Low Months: January, July, and December showed lower volumes, consistent with holiday periods (Eid, Summer break, New Year).
- Average: 3.75 requests per month, with standard deviation of 1.7 requests.

3.4 Request Categories

Requests were categorized by subject matter to identify trends:

Category	Count	% of Total	Example Topics
Healthcare Quality & Performance	14	31.1%	Wait times, patient satisfaction scores, clinical
Financial Information	9	20.0%	Budget allocations, procurement contracts, vendor
Human Resources	7	15.6%	Headcount, training records, organizational charts
Research & Publications	8	17.8%	De-identified patient data, research protocols, cl
Facilities & Operations	4	8.9%	Building maintenance, energy consumption, equipme
Governance & Policy	3	6.7%	Board meeting minutes, policy documents, strategic

Key Insights:

1. Healthcare Quality Dominance: Nearly one-third of requests focused on quality metrics, reflecting public interest in performance accountability.

2. Financial Transparency: 20% of requests sought financial information, particularly procurement contracts and budget details.

3. Research Demand: 8 requests from academic institutions sought de-identified health data for research purposes, highlighting value of our data for evidence-based research.

3.5 Requester Demographics

Requesters were classified by type to understand stakeholder composition:

Requester Type	Count	% of Total	Notes
Individual Citizens	18	40.0%	General public, patients, family members
Researchers / Academics	12	26.7%	Universities, research institutes, students
Media / Journalists	7	15.6%	Newspapers, TV stations, online media
Civil Society Organizations	5	11.1%	NGOs, patient advocacy groups, think tanks
Business / Commercial	3	6.7%	Consultants, vendors, industry associations

Demographic Observations:

- 1. Citizen Engagement: Individual citizens comprised the largest category (40%), demonstrating broad public interest in transparency.
- 2. Academic Research: Significant volume (26.7%) from researchers highlights Company A's role as a data source for health services research.
- 3. Media Interest: 7 media requests (15.6%) generated positive news coverage highlighting our transparency and quality performance.

4. Processing Efficiency & SLA Compliance

4.1 Response Time Performance

Company A achieved excellent processing efficiency in 2024, with all requests responded to within the statutory 30-day service level agreement (SLA).

Response Time Statistics:

Metric	Value	2023 Comparison
Average Response Time	12 days	16 days in 2023 (25% improvement)
Median Response Time	10 days	14 days in 2023
Fastest Response	3 days	5 days in 2023
Longest Response	28 days	30 days in 2023

Regulatory SLA	30 days maximum	30 days (unchanged)
SLA Compliance Rate	100% (45/45)	97.4% (37/38) - 1 SLA breach in 2023

Response Time Distribution:

Time Range	Count	% of Total
1-5 days	8	17.8%
6-10 days	18	40.0%
11-15 days	11	24.4%
16-20 days	5	11.1%
21-30 days	3	6.7%
Over 30 days (SLA breach)	0	0.0%

Performance Drivers:

The 25% improvement in average response time was achieved through:

1. Dedicated FOI Officer: Full-time FOI Officer role (established January 2023) provides consistent focus and expertise.
2. Improved Workflows: Redesigned request intake and tracking process in January 2024 eliminated bottlenecks.
3. Department Engagement: FOI Coordinator network established in each department accelerates record location and review.
4. Technology Tools: Implementation of shared drive for FOI records and Microsoft 365 workflow automation.
5. Training: All department heads completed FOI awareness training in Q1 2024, improving responsiveness.

4.2 SLA Compliance Analysis

Company A achieved 100% SLA compliance in 2024, responding to all 45 requests within the statutory 30-day timeframe. This represents a significant improvement from 2023, which had 1 SLA breach (97.4% compliance).

2024 SLA Compliance:

- Requests Within SLA: 45/45 (100%)
- SLA Breaches: 0
- Average Days Under SLA: 18 days (30-day SLA minus 12-day average response time)

Comparison to Saudi Public Sector Benchmarks:

Organization Type	Average SLA Compliance	Source
Company A	100%	Internal data, 2024
Saudi Healthcare Sector Average	89%	NDMO Benchmark Report, Q3 2024

Saudi Public Sector Average	82%	NDMO Benchmark Report, Q3 2024
International Best Practice	95%+	OECD Public Governance Report, 2024

Company A's 100% SLA compliance places us in the top tier of Saudi public sector organizations and aligns with international best practices.

4.3 Extension Requests

Under Saudi FOI regulations, organizations may request a one-time 30-day extension if a request is exceptionally complex or voluminous. In 2024, Company A did not invoke the extension provision for any requests, demonstrating efficient processing even for complex matters.

Extension Statistics:

Metric	2024	2023	2022
Extension Requests Filed	0	1	2
Requests Requiring Extension	0%	2.6%	8.3%

Complex Request Handling:

While no extensions were required in 2024, three requests were particularly complex and required 20+ days to process:

- 1. Request #24-032 (28 days): Multi-year budget data requiring finance department review, redaction of vendor-sensitive information, and CFO approval.
- 2. Request #24-018 (24 days): De-identified patient outcome data requiring Privacy Officer review, statistical aggregation to prevent re-identification, and IRB consultation.
- 3. Request #24-041 (22 days): Procurement contract portfolio requiring legal review of 15 vendor contracts for commercially sensitive clauses, redaction, and vendor notification.

Despite complexity, all three were completed within the 30-day SLA through effective coordination, prioritization, and resource allocation.

4.4 Internal Consultation Requirements

Many FOI requests require consultation with internal subject matter experts, legal counsel, or privacy officers to ensure appropriate disclosure. In 2024, 23 of 45 requests (51.1%) required internal consultation.

Consultation Breakdown:

Consultation Type	Requests Requiring Consultation	Average Consultation Time
Legal Counsel	12 (26.7% of total)	3-5 days
Privacy Officer (PDPL Review)	15 (33.3% of total)	2-4 days
Chief Information Security Officer (CISO)	6 (13.3% of total)	2-3 days

Chief Financial Officer (CFO)	4 (8.9% of total)	3-6 days
Chief Medical Officer (CMO)	3 (6.7% of total)	2-4 days

Note: Some requests required multiple consultations (e.g., both Legal and Privacy review), so percentages exceed 51.1% total.

Consultation Process:

1. Initial Triage: FOI Officer reviews request and identifies consultation needs within 24 hours of receipt.
2. Consultation Request: FOI Officer sends consultation request to relevant expert(s) with 5-day response deadline.
3. Expert Review: Subject matter expert reviews responsive records and provides disclosure recommendation.
4. Disclosure Decision: FOI Officer makes final decision based on expert input, balancing transparency with legal obligations.
5. Quality Assurance: All denials and partial grants reviewed by Legal Counsel before finalization.

5. Request Outcomes & Denial Analysis

5.1 Fully Granted Requests

The majority of FOI requests (38 requests, 84.4%) were fully granted, meaning all responsive records were disclosed without redaction. This high disclosure rate reflects Company A's commitment to maximum transparency consistent with legal obligations.

Examples of Fully Granted Requests:

1. Request #24-007: Clinic locations and operating hours → Disclosed complete facility directory (already available on website, FOI request expedited disclosure update).
2. Request #24-012: 2024 Budget allocation by department → Disclosed detailed budget spreadsheet showing SAR 2.8B allocation across 12 departments.
3. Request #24-019: Board meeting minutes for Q1-Q3 2024 → Disclosed public summaries of 9 Board meetings (already published in routine publication scheme).
4. Request #24-026: Training completion records for 2024 → Disclosed anonymized statistics showing 96% completion rate for mandatory PDPL training across 850 staff.
5. Request #24-033: Medical equipment inventory for 5 major hospitals → Disclosed complete asset register with 842 major equipment items valued at SAR 450M.

5.2 Partially Granted Requests

Five requests (11.1%) were partially granted, meaning some responsive records were disclosed while others were withheld or redacted under legal exemptions.

Partial Grant Case Studies:

Request #24-015: Employee Salary Data by Grade

- Request: Salary ranges and actual salaries for all employees by grade level.
- Outcome: Partially Granted
- Records Disclosed:
 - Salary ranges by grade (e.g., Grade 8: SAR 12,000-18,000/month)
 - Anonymized distribution showing number of employees in each salary band
 - Total payroll expense by department
- Records Withheld:
 - Individual employee salaries (Personal Data under PDPL, Article 5)
 - Employee names linked to specific salaries
- Legal Basis: PDPL Article 5 protects personal financial information
- Requester Response: Satisfied with anonymized data provided

Request #24-028: Vendor Contract Portfolio

- Request: All vendor contracts exceeding SAR 100,000 signed in 2024.
- Outcome: Partially Granted
- Records Disclosed:
 - Vendor names, contract dates, contract values (total: SAR 385M across 67 contracts)
 - Scope of work summaries
 - Contract performance ratings
- Records Redacted:
 - Commercially sensitive pricing formulas
 - Proprietary vendor methodologies
 - Negotiation strategies and fallback positions
- Legal Basis: Commercial confidentiality (NDMO Regulation 14.3)
- Requester Response: No complaint filed; satisfied with disclosed information

Request #24-039: Patient Safety Incident Reports

- Request: All patient safety incident reports for 2024.
- Outcome: Partially Granted
- Records Disclosed:
 - Aggregated statistics (total incidents: 127, severity breakdown, categories)
 - De-identified case summaries for 15 selected incidents
 - Corrective action plans (redacted for patient identifiers)
- Records Withheld:
 - Individual incident reports containing patient identifiable information
 - Staff names involved in incidents (personnel matter)
- Legal Basis: PDPL Article 6 (patient health data), Personnel privacy
- Requester Response: Satisfied; used aggregated data for research publication

5.3 Denied Requests

Only two requests (4.4%) were completely denied in 2024, both with clear legal justification.

Denial Case Studies:

Request #24-022: Employee Personnel Files

- Request: Personnel files for 5 named employees, including performance reviews, disciplinary records, and medical leave documentation.
- Outcome: DENIED (100% of request)
- Legal Basis:
 - PDPL Article 5: Personal data of employees (names, performance reviews, medical information)
 - Personnel Privacy: Disciplinary records are confidential personnel matters
 - Employment Law: Unauthorized disclosure would violate employee rights
 - FOI Officer Decision: Denied in full. No public interest override justifies disclosure of employee personal data.
 - Requester Notification: Detailed denial letter sent within 8 days, explaining legal basis and appeal rights.
 - Appeal Status: No appeal filed

Request #24-035: Strategic Plan - Classified Sections

- Request: Full, unredacted version of Company A's 3-Year Strategic Plan, including sections marked "CONFIDENTIAL - Board Only."
- Outcome: DENIED (classified sections only; public sections already available on website)
- Legal Basis:
 - Data Classification Policy v3.1: Information classified as CONFIDENTIAL based on Board decision
 - NDMO Regulation 7.2: Protects information that would compromise competitive advantage or strategic positioning
 - Public Interest Test: Disclosure would harm Company A's ability to negotiate partnerships and secure favorable terms, outweighing public interest in disclosure
 - FOI Officer Decision: Denied classified sections. Public sections already disclosed on website (requester was directed to existing publication).
 - Requester Notification: Detailed denial letter sent within 12 days, with Public Interest Test documentation.
 - Appeal Status: No appeal filed

5.4 Legal Basis for Denials

All denials and redactions in 2024 were made pursuant to specific legal exemptions. The following exemptions were invoked:

Legal Exemption	Times Invoked	% of Total Requests
PDPL Article 5 (Personal Data Protection)	6	13.3%
PDPL Article 6 (Health Data Protection)	3	6.7%
Commercial Confidentiality (NDMO Reg 14.3)	2	4.4%
Data Classification - CONFIDENTIAL	1	2.2%
Personnel Privacy	1	2.2%

Public Interest Test:

For all denials and redactions, the FOI Officer conducted a Public Interest Test balancing:

- Public interest in disclosure: Transparency, accountability, informed decision-making
- Public interest in withholding: Privacy protection, commercial interests, organizational effectiveness

In all 7 cases where exemptions were invoked (2 full denials + 5 partial grants), the Public Interest Test supported withholding. Documentation of each Public Interest Test is maintained in the FOI case file.

6. Case Studies

6.1 High-Profile Request: Healthcare Quality Metrics

Request #24-031: Comprehensive Healthcare Quality Dashboard Data

Requester: Dr. Layla Al-Harbi, Health Policy Researcher, King Saud University

Request Summary:

Comprehensive quality metrics for all Company A facilities for 2023-2024, including:

- Patient satisfaction scores by facility and department
- Wait time statistics (emergency, specialist referrals, diagnostic imaging)
- Clinical outcome metrics (readmission rates, surgical complication rates, infection rates)
- Accreditation reports and audit findings
- Complaint volumes and resolution times

Processing Timeline:

- Day 1: Request received via email, logged in FOI tracking system
- Day 2: FOI Officer conducted initial triage, identified need for CMO and Quality Department consultation
- Days 3-7: Quality Department compiled responsive records (850 pages of reports, spreadsheets, dashboards)
- Days 8-10: CMO reviewed records for clinical sensitivity, approved disclosure with minor redactions
- Days 11-12: Privacy Officer reviewed for patient identifiable information, confirmed aggregated data is de-identified
- Day 13: FOI Officer prepared disclosure package with 842 pages (8 pages redacted for patient identifiers in complaint narratives)
- Day 14: Disclosure package sent to requester via secure file transfer

Outcome: PARTIALLY GRANTED (99% disclosure rate, 8 pages redacted)

Records Disclosed:

- 842 pages including:
- Patient satisfaction survey results (aggregated scores, verbatim comments with identifiers removed)
- Wait time statistics (median, average, 90th percentile by facility and service line)
- Clinical outcome dashboards (risk-adjusted readmission rates, HAI rates, surgical SSI rates)
- Accreditation reports from Saudi Central Board for Accreditation of Healthcare Institutions (CBAHI)
- Complaint resolution time statistics

Records Redacted:

- 8 pages of individual complaint narratives containing patient names and clinical details (PDPL Article 6)

Impact:

Dr. Al-Harbi published a peer-reviewed research paper in the Saudi Medical Journal (November 2024) using the disclosed data, which highlighted Company A's above-average performance on key quality metrics. The paper generated positive media coverage and reinforced Company A's reputation as a transparency leader.

6.2 Complex Request: Multi-Year Budget Data

Request #24-032: Historical Budget Data 2020-2024

Requester: Transparency International Saudi Arabia (Civil Society Organization)

Request Summary:

Five years of budget data (2020-2024) with detailed line-item breakdowns by:

- Department
- Capital vs. Operating expenditure
- Approved budget vs. actual expenditure
- Variance explanations
- Budget amendments and reallocations

Processing Timeline:

- Day 1: Request received, logged in FOI tracking system
- Day 2: FOI Officer conducted initial triage, identified need for CFO consultation due to volume and complexity
- Days 3-8: Finance Department located responsive records across multiple systems (SAP financials, Excel planning files, Board presentation decks)
- Days 9-15: CFO and Finance team consolidated data into standardized format, prepared variance narratives
- Days 16-20: Legal Counsel reviewed for commercially sensitive information (vendor pricing, contract negotiation strategies)
- Days 21-25: Redactions applied to 12 pages containing vendor-specific pricing formulas
- Day 26: FOI Officer prepared disclosure package with 156 pages
- Day 28: Disclosure package sent to requester via secure file transfer (2-day delay due to CFO travel schedule for final approval)

Outcome: PARTIALLY GRANTED (92% disclosure rate, 12 pages redacted)

Records Disclosed:

- 156 pages including:
- Annual budget summaries 2020-2024 (approved vs. actual by department)
- Capital expenditure project list with actual costs (SAR 1.2B total over 5 years)
- Operating expenditure trends (payroll, supplies, utilities, outsourced services)
- Budget variance explanations for material variances (>10%)
- Budget amendment logs showing Board-approved reallocations

Records Redacted:

- 12 pages containing vendor-specific pricing formulas and contract negotiation strategies (commercial confidentiality, NDMO Reg 14.3)

Impact:

Transparency International Saudi Arabia published a report (December 2024) highlighting Company A as a best practice example for budget transparency in the Saudi healthcare sector. The organization's Saudi Transparency

Index ranked Company A #2 out of 45 public healthcare entities.

6.3 Denied Request: Employee Personal Data

Request #24-022: Employee Personnel Files

Requester: Investigative journalist (name withheld)

Request Summary:

Complete personnel files for 5 named employees, including:

- Resumes and job applications
- Performance reviews and ratings
- Disciplinary records
- Salary and bonus information
- Medical leave documentation
- Background check reports

Processing Timeline:

- Day 1: Request received, logged in FOI tracking system
- Day 2: FOI Officer conducted initial triage, identified clear PDPL conflict
- Day 3: Legal Counsel consultation confirmed personnel files are protected personal data
- Day 4: FOI Officer conducted Public Interest Test
- Days 5-7: FOI Officer prepared detailed denial letter with legal justification
- Day 8: Denial letter sent to requester via email and registered mail

Outcome: DENIED (100% denial)

Legal Justification:

PDPL Article 5 (Personal Data Protection):

Personnel files contain extensive personal data including:

- Identification information (names, national IDs, addresses, contact details)
- Financial information (salaries, bonuses, bank account numbers)
- Health information (medical leave records, disability accommodations)
- Performance information (reviews, ratings, disciplinary records)

Disclosure would violate employees' fundamental privacy rights under PDPL. Employees did not consent to public disclosure of their personnel information.

Personnel Privacy Principles:

Company A has a legal and ethical obligation to protect employee personnel information. Unauthorized disclosure would:

- Violate employee trust and confidentiality
- Harm employees' professional reputations
- Potentially expose Company A to legal liability for privacy violations
- Create chilling effect on candid performance management

Public Interest Test:

Public Interest in Disclosure:

- Requester argued public interest in oversight of public employees and accountability for performance

Public Interest in Withholding:

- Employee privacy rights under PDPL
- Protection of personnel management integrity
- Prevention of harm to employees
- Compliance with employment law and PDPL

Conclusion: Public interest in withholding substantially outweighs any public interest in disclosure. No exceptional circumstances justify overriding employee privacy rights.

Alternative Disclosure:

FOI Officer offered requester aggregated, anonymized information:

- Organizational chart (job titles, reporting relationships)
- Anonymized performance rating distribution (e.g., "45% of employees rated 'Exceeds Expectations'")
- Salary ranges by grade level
- Anonymized disciplinary statistics (e.g., "12 employees received written warnings in 2024")

Requester Response:

Requester declined alternative disclosure offer. No appeal filed.

7. Complaints & Appeals

7.1 Complaints Received

Company A received 1 complaint in 2024 related to FOI processing, representing a complaint rate of 2.2% (1 complaint out of 45 requests).

Complaint #24-C-001:

Requester: Business consultant (name withheld)

Original Request: Request #24-028 (Vendor Contract Portfolio) - Partially Granted

Complaint Basis: Requester complained that redactions to vendor contract pricing formulas were excessive and unjustified

Date Complaint Received: September 15, 2024

Complaint Investigation Process:

1. Day 1 (Sept 15): Complaint received via email, logged in FOI tracking system
2. Day 2 (Sept 16): FOI Officer acknowledged complaint, committed to 15-day response timeline
3. Days 3-8 (Sept 17-22): FOI Officer reviewed original decision, consulted with Legal Counsel and Procurement Director
4. Day 9 (Sept 23): Re-reviewed redacted sections to determine if additional disclosure possible
5. Day 10 (Sept 24): Determined that original redactions were appropriate and legally justified
6. Days 11-14 (Sept 25-28): Prepared detailed complaint response letter explaining rationale for each redaction
7. Day 15 (Sept 29): Complaint response letter sent to requester

Complaint Outcome: UPHELD ORIGINAL DECISION

Rationale:

The redacted pricing formulas contain proprietary vendor methodologies that, if disclosed, would:

- Harm vendors' competitive positions in future procurements
- Violate contractual confidentiality clauses
- Discourage vendors from participating in future Company A procurements
- Potentially expose Company A to legal liability for breach of contract

Public interest in disclosure does not override these substantial harms. Alternative disclosure (contract values, scope, performance ratings) provides meaningful transparency while protecting commercially sensitive information.

Requester Response:

Requester expressed dissatisfaction but did not file formal appeal.

7.2 Appeals Process

Under Company A's FOI Policy, requesters have the right to appeal denial or redaction decisions to the FOI Appeals Committee within 30 days of receiving a denial or partial grant decision.

FOI Appeals Committee:

- Chair: Chief Data Officer (Ahmed Al-Rashid)
- Members: Chief Legal Officer, Chief Medical Officer, External Member (Professor of Administrative Law, King Saud University)
- Secretary: FOI Officer (non-voting)

Appeal Process:

1. Requester submits written appeal to FOI Officer within 30 days
2. FOI Officer forwards appeal to Appeals Committee within 3 business days
3. Appeals Committee reviews original request, decision, and appeal within 20 business days
4. Appeals Committee may:
 - Uphold original decision
 - Overturn decision and order disclosure
 - Order additional redaction review
 - Request additional information from requester or FOI Officer
5. Appeals Committee decision is final (no further internal appeal)

2024 Appeal Statistics:

Metric	Value
Appeals Filed	0
Appeals Upheld (Original Decision Affirmed)	0
Appeals Granted (Decision Overturned)	0
Appeals Partially Granted	0

- No appeals were filed in 2024. This reflects:
- High quality of initial disclosure decisions
 - Effective legal and privacy consultation process
 - Detailed explanation letters for denials and redactions
 - Proactive offering of alternative disclosures where appropriate

7.3 Outcomes

Overall Complaint & Appeal Performance:

Metric	2024	2023	Industry Benchmark
Complaint Rate	2.2% (1/45)	5.3% (2/38)	8-12% (Saudi public sector)
Appeal Rate	0.0% (0/45)	2.6% (1/38)	5-8% (Saudi public sector)
Complaints Resolved Within 15 Days	100% (1/1)	100% (2/2)	Target: 90%

Company A's low complaint and appeal rates demonstrate high-quality FOI decision-making and requester satisfaction. Our complaint rate of 2.2% is significantly below the Saudi public sector average of 8-12%.

8. Proactive Disclosure Initiatives

8.1 Open Data Portal Expansion

In addition to reactive FOI request processing, Company A is committed to proactive disclosure of information through our Open Data Portal (opendata.companya.gov.sa), launched in February 2024.

Open Data Portal Statistics (2024):

Metric	Value
Total Datasets Published	100 datasets
New Datasets Added in 2024	18 datasets
Total Downloads (2024)	148,220 downloads
Unique Visitors (2024)	45,680 users
API Requests (2024)	2.4 million API calls
Average Data Quality Score	94.8%
Datasets with API Access	52 datasets (52%)

Most Downloaded Open Datasets (2024):

1. COVID-19 Vaccination Data (15,600 downloads) - Anonymized vaccination statistics
2. Parking Availability (12,500 downloads) - Real-time parking data for 12 facilities

- 3. Medical Staff Directory (9,840 downloads) - Public directory of physicians by specialty
- 4. Health Statistics 2023 (8,900 downloads) - Anonymized disease prevalence statistics
- 5. Clinic Locations (5,200 downloads) - Geo-coordinates of all 47 public clinics

Impact of Proactive Disclosure:

The Open Data Portal has significantly reduced reactive FOI request volumes for routine information. For example:

- Before Portal (2023): 8 FOI requests for clinic location data
- After Portal (2024): 1 FOI request for clinic data (requester wanted more detailed operating hours than published)

This demonstrates that proactive disclosure is more efficient than reactive request processing, reducing administrative burden while increasing transparency.

8.2 Routine Publication Scheme

Company A maintains a Routine Publication Scheme, proactively publishing key documents on our website on a regular schedule:

Documents Published Quarterly:

- Board of Directors meeting summaries (public portions)
- Quarterly performance dashboards (quality metrics, financial summaries)
- FOI request statistics (quarterly FOI transparency report)

Documents Published Annually:

- Annual budget (approved and actual expenditure)
- Annual Report (operational and financial performance)
- FOI Annual Report (this document)
- Strategic Plan (public version)
- Audited financial statements

Documents Published Upon Approval:

- Policies (Data Governance, FOI, Privacy, Security)
- Procedures (clinical protocols, administrative processes)
- Organizational charts
- Procurement opportunities and contract awards

2024 Routine Publication Statistics:

Document Category	Documents Published	Total Page Views
Board Meeting Summaries	12 documents	3,450 views
Quarterly Performance Dashboards	4 documents	8,920 views
Annual Reports	5 documents	12,340 views
Policies & Procedures	18 documents	6,780 views
Procurement Notices	67 documents	4,560 views

8.3 Transparency Dashboard

In Q4 2024, Company A launched an interactive Transparency Dashboard on our website, providing real-time visibility into key metrics:

Dashboard Features:

- FOI request statistics (monthly trends, outcomes, response times)
- Open Data Portal metrics (dataset counts, downloads, API usage)
- Budget execution (approved vs. actual expenditure by department)
- Quality performance (patient satisfaction, wait times, clinical outcomes)
- Complaint resolution times

Dashboard Usage (Oct-Dec 2024):

- Unique Visitors: 2,840 users
- Page Views: 8,920 views
- Average Time on Page: 3.2 minutes

The Transparency Dashboard has received positive feedback from stakeholders and will be expanded in 2025 to include additional metrics.

9. Compliance & Quality Assurance

9.1 PDPL Alignment

Company A's FOI program operates in full compliance with the Personal Data Protection Law (PDPL). All disclosure decisions balance transparency with privacy protection.

PDPL Compliance Measures:

1. Privacy Review Process: All FOI requests reviewed by Privacy Officer to identify personal data
2. De-identification Techniques: Use of aggregation, anonymization, and pseudonymization to protect individual privacy while enabling disclosure
3. Consent Assessment: Review of whether data subjects have consented to disclosure (rarely applicable for FOI requests)
4. Public Interest Test: Balancing transparency benefits against privacy risks
5. Redaction Protocols: Use of secure redaction software to permanently remove personal data from disclosed records

2024 PDPL Compliance Audit:

Company A's Internal Audit Department conducted a PDPL compliance audit of the FOI program in November 2024. Audit Result: 98% Compliance (no material findings, 2 minor observations)

Observations:

1. Observation #1: Enhance documentation of Public Interest Test for borderline cases (recommendation: implement standardized template)

2. Observation #2: Provide refresher PDPL training for FOI Coordinators (recommendation: annual training session)

Both observations addressed through implementation of standardized Public Interest Test template (December 2024) and scheduling of Q1 2025 training.

9.2 Internal Audits

In addition to the PDPL-focused audit, the Internal Audit Department conducted a comprehensive FOI program audit in November 2024.

Audit Scope:

- Review of 15 randomly selected FOI case files (33% sample)
- Assessment of compliance with FOI Policy v2.0
- Evaluation of SLA compliance and response time performance
- Review of denial and redaction justifications
- Assessment of complaint and appeal handling

Audit Results:

Overall Rating: 96% Compliance (High Maturity)

Strengths Identified:

- ■ Excellent SLA compliance (100% in sample)
- ■ Well-documented disclosure decisions with clear legal justifications
- ■ Effective consultation process with legal and privacy experts
- ■ High requester satisfaction (evidenced by low complaint rate)
- ■ Robust record-keeping and case file documentation

Opportunities for Improvement:

- Implement online FOI request portal to replace email-based process (planned for Q2 2025)
- Enhance FOI Coordinator training program (annual refresher planned for Q1 2025)
- Develop metrics dashboard for real-time FOI performance monitoring (completed in Q4 2024 via Transparency Dashboard)

Management Response:

FOI Officer accepted all audit recommendations and developed implementation plan tracked in GRC system.

9.3 Staff Training

Company A invested significantly in FOI training in 2024 to build organizational capacity and ensure consistent, high-quality disclosure decisions.

Training Activities:

Q1 2024: FOI Awareness Training for All Department Heads

- Participants: 45 department heads and senior managers
- Duration: 2-hour interactive workshop
- Topics Covered:

- FOI program overview and legal framework
- Roles and responsibilities of department FOI Coordinators
- How to locate and compile responsive records
- Privacy and classification considerations
- Response time expectations
- Evaluation: 4.6/5.0 average satisfaction score

Q2 2024: Advanced FOI Training for FOI Officer and Deputy

- Participants: 2 (FOI Officer Mariam Al-Shehri, Deputy FOI Officer Salem Al-Qahtani)
- Provider: NDMO National Training Institute
- Duration: 3-day intensive course
- Topics Covered:
 - Complex disclosure decision-making
 - Redaction techniques and tools
 - Managing high-profile and sensitive requests
 - Appeal and complaint resolution
 - International FOI best practices
- Certification: Both participants earned NDMO FOI Specialist certification

Q3 2024: PDPL and Privacy Training for FOI Team

- Participants: 4 (FOI Officer, Deputy FOI Officer, Legal Counsel, Privacy Officer)
- Provider: Saudi Data & AI Authority (SDAIA)
- Duration: 1-day workshop
- Topics Covered:
 - PDPL requirements for FOI requests
 - De-identification and anonymization techniques
 - Public Interest Test methodology
 - Case studies of privacy-sensitive FOI requests

Q4 2024: FOI Coordinator Network Kickoff

- Participants: 12 department FOI Coordinators
- Duration: 1-hour quarterly meeting (ongoing)
- Topics Covered:
 - FOI statistics and trends
 - Lessons learned from recent requests
 - Process improvements and best practices
 - Q&A and troubleshooting

Total Training Investment (2024):

- Staff Hours: 156 hours
- External Training Costs: SAR 45,000
- Internal Facilitation Time: 32 hours

This training investment has directly contributed to improved response times, higher disclosure rates, and reduced complaints.

10. Continuous Improvement

10.1 Lessons Learned

Based on analysis of 2024 FOI requests, Company A identified several lessons learned and best practices:

Lesson #1: Proactive Disclosure Reduces Reactive Request Burden

The launch of the Open Data Portal in February 2024 reduced FOI requests for routine information. For example, clinic location data and budget summaries that previously generated multiple FOI requests are now self-service via the portal.

Action: Expand Open Data Portal from 100 to 125 datasets in 2025, prioritizing frequently requested information.

Lesson #2: Detailed Denial Letters Reduce Complaints and Appeals

The FOI Officer implemented a practice of providing highly detailed denial letters explaining the legal basis, Public Interest Test, and alternative disclosure options. This contributed to 0 appeals in 2024.

Action: Formalize detailed denial letter template as mandatory practice in FOI Procedure Manual (to be updated in Q1 2025).

Lesson #3: Early Legal/Privacy Consultation Accelerates Processing

Requests that received legal or privacy consultation within the first 3 days had an average response time of 10 days, compared to 16 days for requests where consultation occurred later.

Action: Implement mandatory 24-hour triage process with immediate consultation flagging for complex requests.

Lesson #4: Department FOI Coordinator Network Improves Responsiveness

Establishing informal FOI Coordinators in each department (Q1 2024) reduced average record location time from 5 days to 2 days.

Action: Formalize FOI Coordinator role with position descriptions, training requirements, and performance metrics.

Lesson #5: Requester Engagement Improves Outcomes

For complex requests, the FOI Officer proactively contacted requesters to clarify scope and discuss alternative formats. This reduced processing time and improved requester satisfaction.

Action: Implement standard practice of requester contact within 48 hours for requests exceeding 50 pages of responsive records.

10.2 Technology Enhancements

Company A plans significant technology investments in 2025 to modernize the FOI program:

Q2 2025: Online FOI Request Portal

Current State: Requests submitted via email, manually logged in Excel spreadsheet

Future State: Online portal integrated with SharePoint, automated workflow, requester self-service tracking

Benefits:

- Improved requester experience (24/7 submission, status tracking)
- Reduced manual data entry for FOI Officer
- Automated email notifications and deadline tracking
- Analytics dashboard for real-time performance monitoring

Investment: SAR 120,000 (portal development, SharePoint configuration, training)

Q3 2025: Redaction Software

Current State: Manual redaction using Adobe Acrobat (time-consuming, potential for errors)

Future State: Automated redaction software with AI-powered personal data detection

Benefits:

- Faster redaction process (estimated 50% time savings)
- Reduced risk of inadvertent disclosure
- Consistent redaction quality
- Audit trail of redaction decisions

Investment: SAR 75,000 (software license, training, configuration)

Q4 2025: Integration with Document Management System

Current State: FOI Officer manually searches multiple systems (SharePoint, email, network drives) to locate responsive records

Future State: Integration with OpenText Document Management System for automated record location

Benefits:

- Faster record location (estimated 40% time savings)
- More comprehensive search results
- Reduced risk of missing responsive records
- Better version control and audit trail

Investment: SAR 95,000 (integration development, testing, training)

10.3 Process Optimization

In addition to technology enhancements, Company A will implement process improvements in 2025:

Process Improvement #1: Standardized Request Triage

Implement standardized triage checklist within 24 hours of request receipt to classify complexity, identify consultation needs, and set realistic response timelines.

Expected Impact: 15% reduction in average response time (from 12 days to 10 days)

Process Improvement #2: FOI Case Management Template

Develop standardized case management template for documenting:

- Request scope and responsive records

- Consultation recommendations
- Public Interest Test analysis
- Disclosure decision rationale
- Requester communications

Expected Impact: Improved audit trail, reduced risk of errors, enhanced training for new staff

Process Improvement #3: Quarterly Performance Reviews

Implement quarterly FOI performance review meetings with Executive Leadership to:

- Review statistics and trends
- Identify systemic issues
- Approve process improvements
- Allocate resources as needed

Expected Impact: Enhanced executive visibility and accountability, faster resolution of systemic issues

Process Improvement #4: Requester Satisfaction Survey

Implement systematic requester satisfaction survey sent to all requesters within 1 week of case closure.

Expected Impact: Continuous feedback loop for identifying service improvements, benchmark for performance measurement

10.4 2025 Roadmap

Company A's FOI program roadmap for 2025 includes the following strategic initiatives:

Q1 2025 (January-March):

- Publish FOI Annual Report 2024 (this document) by January 31
- Conduct annual FOI Coordinator training session
- Update FOI Policy v2.0 based on lessons learned
- Implement standardized Public Interest Test template
- Launch quarterly FOI statistics publication

Q2 2025 (April-June):

- Launch online FOI request portal (target: May 1, 2025)
- Expand Open Data Portal to 115 datasets
- Conduct requester satisfaction survey pilot
- Implement automated SLA tracking and alerts

Q3 2025 (July-September):

- Implement redaction software
- Publish mid-year FOI performance report
- Conduct FOI program external benchmarking study
- Launch multilingual support (Arabic + English) for FOI requests

Q4 2025 (October-December):

- Integrate FOI system with OpenText Document Management System

- Expand Open Data Portal to 125 datasets
- Conduct FOI program maturity assessment
- Prepare 2025 FOI Annual Report

Performance Targets for 2025:

Metric	2024 Actual	2025 Target	Stretch Goal
Average Response Time	12 days	9 days	7 days
SLA Compliance Rate	100%	100%	100%
Overall Disclosure Rate	95.6%	95%+	97%+
Complaint Rate	2.2%	<3%	<2%
Appeal Rate	0%	<2%	0%
Requester Satisfaction	4.3/5.0	4.4/5.0	4.6/5.0
Open Data Portal Datasets	100	125	135

Conclusion

Company A's FOI program achieved excellent performance in 2024, demonstrating our commitment to transparency, accountability, and compliance with NDMO regulations and PDPL requirements. Key achievements include:

- 100% SLA compliance - all 45 requests responded to within 30 days
- 95.6% disclosure rate - among the highest in Saudi public sector
- 12-day average response time - 25% improvement from 2023
- Low complaint rate (2.2%) - significantly below sector average
- Zero appeals - reflecting high-quality decision-making
- Proactive disclosure - 100 datasets on Open Data Portal with 148,220 downloads

Company A is committed to continuous improvement and will implement significant enhancements in 2025, including an online FOI portal, redaction software, and expanded proactive disclosure. These investments will further improve efficiency, transparency, and requester satisfaction.

We welcome feedback from the public, researchers, media, and other stakeholders on our FOI program. Together, we can build a culture of openness and accountability in Saudi Arabia's healthcare sector.

Appendix A: FOI Request Form Template

Company A - Freedom of Information Request Form

Requester Information:

- Full Name: _____

- Email Address: _____
- Phone Number: _____
- Mailing Address (if hard copy response preferred): _____
- Organization (if applicable): _____

Request Details:

- Subject Matter of Request: _____
- Detailed Description of Information Requested:

- Preferred Format (email, hard copy, USB drive): _____
- Preferred File Format (PDF, Excel, Word, etc.): _____
- Purpose of Request (optional, helps us provide better service): _____

Acknowledgement:

I understand that:

- Company A will respond within 30 days of receipt
- Some information may be withheld or redacted under legal exemptions (PDPL, classification, etc.)
- I have the right to complain or appeal if dissatisfied with the outcome
- Fees may apply for document reproduction (SAR 1 per page for hard copies)

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Submit to: foi@companya.gov.sa or mail to FOI Officer, Company A, P.O. Box 12345, Riyadh, Saudi Arabia

Appendix B: Legal Exemptions Summary

Company A applies the following legal exemptions to protect sensitive information:

Exemption	Legal Basis	Examples
Personal Data	PDPL Article 5	Employee names/salaries, patient identifiers, pers
Health Data	PDPL Article 6	Patient medical records, diagnosis codes, treatmen
Commercial Confidentiality	NDMO Reg 14.3	Vendor pricing formulas, contract negotiation stra
Classified Information	Data Classification Policy	Information classified as SECRET or CONFIDENTIAL b
Personnel Privacy	Employment Law	Disciplinary records, performance reviews, personn
Security	NDMO Reg 11.2	Information that would compromise physical or cybe
Legal Privilege	Saudi Legal Practice Law	Attorney-client communications, legal advice, liti

All exemptions are applied narrowly, with maximum disclosure consistent with legal obligations.

Appendix C: FOI Team Contact Information

FOI Officer:

Mariam Al-Shehri

Email: foi@companya.gov.sa

Phone: +966-11-234-5678

Office: Building A, Room 305

Deputy FOI Officer:

Salem Al-Qahtani

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Phone: +966-11-234-5679

Legal Support:

Khalid Al-Manea, Legal Counsel

Email: legal@companya.gov.sa

Phone: +966-11-234-5680

Mailing Address:

FOI Officer

Company A

P.O. Box 12345

Riyadh 11564

Saudi Arabia

Website: www.companya.gov.sa/foi

Open Data Portal: opendata.companya.gov.sa

Appendix D: Glossary of Terms

FOI (Freedom of Information): The right of individuals and organizations to access information held by public sector entities, subject to legal exemptions.

PDPL (Personal Data Protection Law): Saudi Arabia's comprehensive data privacy legislation (Royal Decree M/19, 2021) protecting personal data of individuals.

NDMO (National Data Management Office): Saudi regulatory body overseeing national data management standards and compliance (191 controls across 15 domains).

SLA (Service Level Agreement): Commitment to respond to FOI requests within a specified timeframe (30 days for Company A).

Redaction: The process of removing or obscuring sensitive information from disclosed records to protect privacy or other legal interests.

Public Interest Test: Balancing exercise weighing public interest in disclosure against public interest in withholding information under legal exemptions.

Proactive Disclosure: Publication of information without waiting for an FOI request (e.g., Open Data Portal, routine publication scheme).

Requester: Individual or organization submitting an FOI request.

Responsive Records: Documents, data, or information that fall within the scope of an FOI request.

De-identification: Removal or modification of personal identifiers to protect individual privacy while enabling data sharing (e.g., aggregation, anonymization).

Exemption: Legal basis for withholding or redacting information (e.g., personal data, commercial confidentiality, security).

Appeal: Formal challenge to an FOI denial or redaction decision, reviewed by FOI Appeals Committee.

Complaint: Expression of dissatisfaction with FOI processing (e.g., delay, inadequate search, excessive redaction), investigated by FOI Officer.

END OF REPORT

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